ship ones like PM Kisan Samman Nidhi (in which the central government transfers Rs 6,000 a year to farmers, and the Karnataka government contributes an additional Rs 4,000) and the Jal Jeevan Mission under which 4 million families in Karnataka have got access to tap water. Connectivity and infrastructure via new highways, railways and airports are other themes. Alongside this are the Bommai government's array of welfare schemes, including the Raitha Vidya Nidhi scholarships for farmers' children; agriculture subsidies; women empowerment schemes like Grihini Shakthi offering Rs 1,000 monthly assistance to landless women farm labourers; free bus passes to working women and students. "Overall," says Bommai, "the 'double-engine' schemes have covered over 5 crore beneficiaries of Karnataka's total 6 crore population. We are confident that this alone will enable us to be re-elected."

While making price rice, corruption and unemployment its three main campaign issues, the Congress is not far behind on the welfare game. The party announced four guarantees: free electricity of up to 200 units for every household; Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for every woman who's the head of her family; doubling the free distribution of rice for below the poverty line families to 10 kg; monthly allowances of Rs 3,000 for unemployed graduates and Rs 1,500 for diploma holders for a two-year period. As part of its voter outreach, the party has distributed posters to thousands of households listing the four guarantees with the photos and signatures of Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar as guarantors. The Congress also promises to review the issue of reservations, saying the BJP government's quota increases are only on paper and won't stand legal scrutiny.

Meanwhile, the fact that the JD(S) has picked up several rebels from both sides adds a significant dimension to the contest. The regional party, with the 63-year-old Kumaraswamy leading its campaign, will likely make the contest triangular in southern Karnataka and make it a close fight in a few other pockets. With both his stints in office being shortlived, Kumaraswamy is now eyeing a third term, for which he is going all-out, including undertaking a four-month-long road campaign during which he put in 18-hour workdays despite having had heart surgery twice in the past. The JD(S)'s election campaign is built around five welfare themes, called the *pancharathna*—affordable education, health, agriculture, employment and housing. The JD(S) manifesto also promises a whole host of other welfare measures. However, weighing the party down are allegations that it remains heavily reliant on the Deve Gowda family.

THE MODI FACTOR

While BJP strategists claim their governments' welfare measures have helped the party boost its seat expectations from around 70 to 100 a fortnight before voting day, they are relying heavily on the X factor PM Modi will bring to the table. They believe his blitzkrieg-like campaign in the final phase will push them well past the majority figure. One of the strategies being worked out is for the PM to tell voters that by bringing new faces into the poll fray, the BJP is sensitive to their demands for change and acting on it. The party will also be fielding a host of star campaigners. Besides the PM, who is lining up at least 20 rallies starting this week, the BJP will have 11 Union ministers and three chief ministers—Yogi Adityanath, Himanta Biswa Sarma and Shivraj Singh Chouhan—besides Maharashtra deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis among its star campaigners. The Congress, meanwhile, is lining up its own galaxy, with Rahul Gandhi already having hit the road with rallies and roadshows, and three chief ministers—Ashok Gehlot of Rajasthan, Bhupesh Baghel of Chhattisgarh and Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu of Himachal Pradesh—being enlisted on the campaign trail.

Psephologists say with Karnataka being prosperous, welfare measures have limited appeal; voters instead want rapid development of infrastructure and a party that has an expansive vision for the state

What do psephologists make of their prospects? Shastri believes that while the PM's blitzkrieg of road shows is unprecedented, local issues influence Karnataka voters more. The PM's efforts, though, will stand him in good stead for the 2024 general election. Karnataka voters, Shastri adds, have routinely exhibited this dichotomy of voting for one party in the state and a different one in the general election. Deshmukh of CVoter argues that by bringing in fresh faces, the BJP has been able to soften the impact of anti-incumbency. He thinks Modi's carpet-bombing campaign may help improve the BJP's prospects, too, since, as he says, "the prime minister is known to hit an electoral equivalent of a six even off the back foot".

Psephologist Pradeep Gupta of Axis My India, whose poll predictions are usually bang on, believes that Karnataka being a relatively prosperous state, welfare measures have limited appeal; a larger percentage of voters hope for rapid development of infrastructure and amenities that in turn create employment. He surmises that the party that focuses on an expansive vision of Karnataka is more likely to gain traction rather than one that focuses on grouses like price rise and unemployment. Gupta also says that since the 2018 polls produced a hung house, the Karnataka voter is likely to give one party a clear mandate this time rather than a mishmash of coalitions. Gupta is reluctant to hazard a guess on the winner, only that "it's still a tough fight". One will have to wait for results to be announced on May 13 to know who gets to rule this politically and economically important southern state. ■